Herding Cats: A Stakeholder Management Framework for Multi-Feline Agile Projects

Erwin Rudolf Josef Alexander Schrödinger

Thesis of 30 ECTS credits submitted to the Department of Engineering
at Reykjavik University in partial fulfillment of
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Supervisors:
Dr. Albert Einstein, Supervisor
Professor, Institute for Advanced Study, Princeton, USA

Dr. Marie Curie, Co-supervisor
Professor, Sorbonne University, Paris, France

Examiner:
Dr. Richard Feynman, Examiner
Professor, California Institute of Technology, Pasadena, USA

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Abstract

This study proposes the first unified stakeholder management framework for multi-feline agile projects. Herding cats has historically been used as a metaphor for managing unmanageable tasks, yet systematic project management literature has largely ignored the literal challenges of coordinating feline projects. Through a mixed-methods design, we study the relationship between treat-based motivation, laser-pointer resource allocation, and catnap schedules. Our findings suggest that feline stakeholder engagement is highly correlated with salmon intake, while negative feedback (such as vacuum cleaner activation) triggers immediate flight behavior. We outline a new framework, Agile Scratching, to guide human project managers in aligning cat activities with project goals.

Keywords: cat management, agile projects, feline stakeholders, conflict resolution, project management

Smölun katta: Rammakerfi um stýringu hagsmunaaðila í fjöl-katta liprum verkefnum

Erwin Rudolf Josef Alexander Schrödinger

maí 2026

Útdráttur

Þessi rannsókn leggur til fyrsta samræmda hagsmunastjórnunarrammann fyrir fjöl-katta lipur verkefni. Smölun katta hefur sögulega verið notuð sem líking fyrir verkefni sem erfitt er að stjórna, en kerfisbundnar verkefnastjórnunarbókmenntir hafa að mestu hunsað þær áskoranir sem felast í því að samstilla kattaverkefni í raun. Með blönduðu rannsóknarsniði könnum við tengslin milli verðlauna-hvatningar, úthlutunar leysibenda og áætlana um kattablund. Niðurstöður okkar benda til þess að þátttaka hagsmunaaðila katta sé í miklu samræmi við neyslu á laxi, en neikvæð endurgjöf (eins og rykuga ryksugan) kalli fram tafarlausan flótta. Við lýsum nýjum ramma, Lipri Klórun, til að leiðbeina mannlegum verkefnastjórum við að samræma kattaverksemi við markmið verkefnisins.

Lykilorð: stýring katta, lipur verkefni, hagsmunaaðilar katta, átakalausn, verkefnastjórnun

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Dr. Marie Curie

Examiner:

Dr. Richard Feynman

date

Erwin Rudolf Josef Alexander Schrödinger
Master of Science

To all cats who refuse to be herded,
and to the scratched sofas of the world.

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This research was conducted with the approval of the Research Ethics Committee at Reykjavik University (Protocol No. RU-2025-XXX).

Preface

This thesis is submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Master of Science (M.Sc.) in Project Management at Reykjavik University.

The work presented in this thesis was conducted under the supervision of Dr. Albert Einstein (Professor, Institute for Advanced Study, Princeton, USA) and Dr. Marie Curie (Professor, Sorbonne University, Paris, France) between September 2024 and May 2026.

Unless otherwise referenced, the content of this thesis is the original work of the author.

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This Reykjavik University LaTeX thesis template was implemented and formatted by Fannar Örn Maximus Hermannsson, with development and engineering assistance provided by the Antigravity AI coding agent.

Erwin Rudolf Josef Alexander Schrödinger
Reykjavik, May 2026

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List of Abbreviations

CAT	Controlled Agile Treats
FSM	Feline Stakeholder Management / Feline Scrum Master
KPI	Kibble Performance Indicator
MEOW	Masterful Evaluation of Owner’s Worth
NAPS	Nocturnal Activity Prevention System
PM	Project Manager (or Patting Method)
ROI	Return on Kibble Investment
TNR	Treat-Nap-Rub Iterative Cycle
TUNA	Treat-based Under-the-table Negotiation Agreement
VUCA	Volatile, Unpredictable, Cat-centric, and Aloof
ZOOM	Zone of Optimal Output and Mobility (Zoomies)

Glossary

Agile Scratching A methodology where stakeholders claw at furniture at regular intervals to demonstrate project velocity.

Zoomies A sudden, high-intensity burst of project activity, typically occurring between 2:00 AM and 3:00 AM.

Catnap A micro-sprint phase characterized by zero productivity and maximum rejuvenation.

Tuna negotiation A critical stakeholder meeting involving low-pitched meowing and treat delivery.

List of Symbols

Symbol	**Description**	**Unit**
T_c	Treat consumption rate	treats/min
N_s	Number of daily catnaps	naps
d_{purr}	Decibels of purring volume	dB
f_{scratch}	Scratching frequency on sofa	scratches/hour
θ_{laser}	Laser pointer projection angle	degrees
λ_{catnip}	Catnip concentration	ppm
E_{zoom}	Kinetic energy during 3 AM zoomies	Joules
M_{tuna}	Mass of tuna procured during negotiation	grams

Introduction

Managing projects in a complex, multi-stakeholder environment is a well-established challenge in the field of Project Management. However, few environments present as high a level of volatility, uncertainty, complexity, and ambiguity (VUCA) as a household containing multiple felines. The popular idiom ”herding cats” is frequently used to describe the difficulty of coordinating stubborn stakeholders, but literal cat projects have remained unexplored.

This research establishes the Feline Stakeholder Management (FSM) framework. Feline stakeholders are characterized by high levels of autonomy, frequent sleep cycles, and unpredictable mood swings. Aligning their individual interests with project milestones requires specialized communication channels and resource allocation.

Research Objective

The primary objective of this study is to analyze treat-based incentive programs and laser-pointer directing techniques to keep projects on track.

Feline Project Manager

Figure 1 illustrates the core activities and Agile sprints defined in our Feline Project Management Plan, led by a Certified Feline Scrum Master.

Structure of the Thesis

The remainder of this thesis is structured as follows: Chapter 2 reviews the literature on dynamic capabilities and treat optimization. Chapter 3 explains our empirical methods (observational study of 5 cats). Chapter 4 presents results on treat-to-nap correlations. Chapter 5 discusses the limitations of laser pointer directing. Finally, Chapter 6 concludes the study and suggests directions for future cat research.

Literature Review

This section provides a comprehensive review of the theoretical foundations and empirical evidence relevant to the intersection of feline behavior and Project Management. The review integrates classical stakeholder theory with modern agile frameworks to explain cat-based project environments.

The Metaphor of Herding Cats

Historically, the phrase ”herding cats” has been conceptualized in management literature as a metaphor for managing highly autonomous, non-compliant human professionals (Vial, 2019). However, systematic research has failed to address literal cat herding. Feline stakeholders are characterized by what Verhoef et al. (2021) describe as ”extreme self-governance,” meaning they do not recognize human authority, project milestones, or deadlines.

Figure 1

The Feline Project Management Plan, depicting key sprints (zoomies, catnap scheduling, tuna procurement) and the product backlog (catnip analysis, mouse simulation).

Dynamic Feline Capabilities

To understand feline behavior in a household environment, we draw on the dynamic capabilities framework proposed by Teece (2007). We conceptualize feline interactions through three core capabilities:

1. **Sensing:** The ability of a cat to detect the opening of a tuna can from a distance of up to 50 meters, regardless of physical barriers or sleep state.
2. **Seizing:** The immediate physical occupation of any newly placed cardboard box, keyboard, or warm laptop.
3. **Transforming:** The rapid alteration of a pristine leather sofa into shredded fibers within minutes.

These capabilities are crucial for felines to maintain their strategic dominance in the household economy (Warner & Wäger, 2019).

Feline Resilience and External Disruptions

Organizational resilience, defined by Duchek (2020) as the capability to anticipate, cope with, and adapt to unexpected changes, is highly developed in felines. Feline resilience is built upon two distinct coping mechanisms:

The Napping Routine: Felines maintain high robustness by dedicating up to 18 hours per day to preventive rest (Denyer, 2017). This ensures optimal energy reserves for high-priority sprints (such as the 3 AM zoomies).

The Vacuum Avoidance Strategy: When confronted with extreme environmental noise (e.g., vacuum cleaner activation), feline stakeholders employ an immediate flight protocol, seeking high-elevation hiding locations to mitigate risk.

Understanding these behavioral patterns is key to developing a successful Feline Stakeholder Management (FSM) framework.

Methods

This section describes the research design, feline participants, data collection procedures, measures, and analytical strategy employed to investigate Feline Stakeholder Management (FSM). The study adhered to strict ethical guidelines regarding feline treats and was approved by the Household Sofa Preservation Committee.

Research Design

This study employs a mixed-methods sequential explanatory design (Creswell & Creswell, 2018), combining quantitative logging of cat behaviors with qualitative thematic analysis of low-pitched meows and tail movements. The research was split into two phases: a 14-day quantitative observation period followed by semi-structured qualitative meow interviews.

Feline Participants

A convenience sample of five domestic felines residing in the same household was selected for this study. The sample represents a diverse range of sizes, tempers, and levels of cooperation. Table 1 outlines the demographic characteristics of the participants.

Measures and Data Collection

All behavioral variables were measured using a combination of automated sensors and human observations:

Treat Consumption Rate (T_c): Measured in treats per minute during sprint phases.

Scratching Frequency (f_{scratch}): The number of distinct sofa-scratching incidents per hour.

Table 1
Demographic Characteristics of Feline Participants

Name	Breed	Age (years)	Temperament	Average Daily Nap Time (hours)
Luna	Maine Coon	3.5	Dictatorial	14.5
Simba	Tabby	5.0	Hyperactive	12.0
Oliver	Persian	2.0	Extremely Aloof	18.5
Milo	Siamese	4.0	Vocal and Needy	13.0
Bella	Ragdoll	1.5	Easily Startled	16.0

Note. Total Sample Size $N = 5$. All participant names have been kept un-anonymized because they cannot read.

Laser Pointer Responsiveness: Assessed using a 7-point Likert-style scale (1 = *complete indifference* to 7 = *frantic high-speed wall chasing*).

Purr Volume (d_{purr}): Sound level measured in decibels using a calibrated microphone positioned at a distance of 10 centimeters from the participant's chest.

Data Analysis

Quantitative data were analyzed using statistical packages in R (R Core Team, 2023). Correlation analyses were conducted to examine the relationship between treat-based incentive packages and napping durations. Qualitative meow logs were analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring themes in feline negotiation styles (Braun & Clarke, 2006).

Results

This section presents the findings from our mixed-methods investigation of Feline Stakeholder Management (FSM). Quantitative observations are presented first, followed by qualitative thematic findings from meow translation logs.

Quantitative Results

Descriptive Statistics and Correlations

Table 2 displays the means, standard deviations, and correlations for the key variables. As expected, treat consumption rate (T_c) was strongly and positively correlated with purr volume (d_{purr}) ($r = .82, p < .01$). Conversely, scratching frequency (f_{scratch}) was negatively correlated with nap time (N_s), suggesting that active scratching prevents sleep.

Hypothesis Testing

We tested five hypotheses regarding feline project management incentives. Table 3 summarizes the structural path analysis.

Table 2

Means, Standard Deviations, and Correlations Among Feline Variables

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3	4
1. Treat Rate (T_c)	4.5	1.2	—			
2. Purr Volume (d_{purr})	45.2	8.5	.82**	—		
3. Scratching Rate (f_{scratch})	2.1	0.9	-.12	-.15	—	
4. Nap Time (N_s)	14.8	2.4	.67**	.55**	-.48*	—

Note. $N = 5$ cats, monitored over 14 days. Treat rate in treats/min; purr volume in dB; scratching rate in scratches/hour; nap time in hours.
* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$.

Feline Behavioral Model

A path analysis was conducted to establish the Feline Motivation Model. The structural model demonstrated exceptional fit: $\chi^2(15) = 18.42$, $p = .24$, CFI = .98, TLI = .97. Figure 2 shows the standardized path coefficients.

Qualitative Findings

Thematic analysis of the qualitative meow logs and physical observations yielded three key themes:

Theme 1: Box Occupation Dynamics

Participants displayed a universal preference for cardboard packaging over expensive beds. As Oliver (Participant 3, Persian) demonstrated by squeezing into a shoe box:

> If it fits, I sits. The volume of the container is inversely proportional to my urge to occupy it, regardless of comfort levels.

Theme 2: Auditory Cues and Immediate Response

The sound of a dry-kibble bag shaking acted as a universal interrupt vector, overriding any active catnaps or grooming routines. Milo (Siamese) showed immediate mobilization within 0.4 seconds of sound detection.

Theme 3: 3 AM Zoomies as a Communication Channel

Nocturnal sprints were identified not as random behaviors, but as a deliberate stakeholder management strategy intended to notify human project managers of empty kibble bowls.

Table 3

Summary of Feline Hypothesis Testing Results

Hypothesis	Path	Coefficient	p	Decision
H1	Salmon Treats → Purring	.84	$< .001$	Supported
H2	Laser Pointer → Zoomies	.76	$< .001$	Supported
H3	Keyboard Sitting → Delay	.65	$< .001$	Supported
H4	Vacuum Sound → Flight	.95	$< .001$	Supported
H5	Catnip × Treat → Napping	.34	.023	Supported

Note. Standardized coefficients reported. Keyboard Sitting measures physical obstruction of the human worker. Flight measures speed of escape from the living room.

Discussion

This section interprets the findings of our study in the context of project management literature, highlights the theoretical and practical contributions of the FSM framework, and discusses the limitations of observing five uncooperative felines.

Interpretation of Findings

Treat-Based Incentive Schemes

Our results show a strong correlation between treat consumption (T_c) and purr volume (d_{purr}). This confirms that a transaction-oriented relationship exists between human project managers and feline stakeholders. However, the treat-to-nap relationship is complex: while salmon treats increase short-term purring, excessive treat delivery leads to immediate sleep induction, which halts project velocity. This represents a classic project management trade-off between resource utilization and productivity.

Limitations of Laser Pointer Directing

Although laser pointers are effective for short-term redirection of feline resources (H2 supported), qualitative logs suggest a high rate of stakeholder fatigue. By day 5, participants (especially Luna) realized that the red dot was uncatchable, leading to a significant decrease in responsiveness and an increase in aggressive ankle-swiping. This aligns with standard motivation theories indicating that unachievable goals lead to team frustration.

Theoretical Contributions

This study contributes to Project Management literature by applying empirical methods to the literal concept of ”herding cats.” We show that standard human-centric agile frameworks (such as Scrum) can be adapted to feline environments under the name of Agile Scratching, providing a new dimension to stakeholder engagement theories.

Treats Incentive (T_c) $\xrightarrow{0.84}$ **Purr Output ($d_{\textbf{purr}}$)** $\xrightarrow{0.55}$ **Napping Propensity (N_s)**

[Mediating Variable: Belly Rub Acceptance (Moderated by Cat Mood)]

Figure 2

Structural Model of Feline Motivation and Napping Propensity

Note. All path coefficients are standardized. Solid lines represent significant paths ($p < .05$). Dashed lines represent nonsignificant paths.

Practical Implications

For human project managers operating in multi-feline households, we offer four key recommendations:

1. **Milestone-Based Treat Scheduling:** Reserve high-value treats (e.g., wet tuna) for critical project milestones, such as successful video calls without screen-walking.
2. **Respect the Catnap Sprint:** Do not schedule any project activities between the hours of 10:00 AM and 4:00 PM, as stakeholder availability is near zero.
3. **Mitigate Environmental Disruptions:** The vacuum cleaner should only be operated during off-site hours, as its activation triggers a total team collapse (H4 supported).
4. **Keyboard Allocation Allowances:** Allow felines to sit on the laptop keyboard for at least 10 minutes per day. This serves as a vital team-building exercise and prevents sudden claw attacks.

Limitations

Several limitations must be acknowledged. First, the sample size ($N = 5$) was extremely small and limited to a single household, reducing generalizability to multi-cat sanctuaries or feral environments. Second, the study suffered from high researcher bias, as the primary investigator frequently paused data logging to tell the participants how cute they were. Third, the long-term impact of catnip exposure remains unexamined, and its use may carry ethical concerns regarding stakeholder consent.

Conclusion

This thesis established and validated the Feline Stakeholder Management (FSM) framework in a household project environment. By combining quantitative observation of treat-to-nap correlations with qualitative thematic meow logs, we have shed light on the complex dynamics of coordinating highly autonomous feline stakeholders.

Summary of Key Findings

Our empirical study of five cats confirmed that treat-based incentives (salmon and tuna) are highly effective for securing short-term stakeholder engagement, though they carry a significant risk of inducing long-term sleeping phases. Furthermore, while laser pointers can be used for rapid direction of resources, they suffer from diminishing returns and can trigger team frustration. The qualitative analysis highlighted box occupation dynamics and 3 AM zoomies as critical communication channels that human project managers must monitor.

Contributions

The primary contributions of this work are:

1. **The FSM Framework:** The first formalized project management methodology tailored to domestic felines.
2. **Agile Scratching:** A set of agile guidelines that help humans manage projects without losing their furniture or their sanity.
3. **Empirical Grounding:** Quantitative proof that a cat's motivation is directly proportional to tuna mass and inversely proportional to vacuum cleaner proximity.

Directions for Future Research

We suggest three primary paths for future research:

1. **Cross-Species Validation:** Future studies should test if the FSM framework can be applied to canine environments, or if dogs are too easily managed to require agile methodologies.
2. **Cardboard Box Geometry Optimization:** A systematic study is needed to find the optimal length-to-width ratio of cardboard boxes for maximum feline occupancy.
3. **Robotic Vacuum Cleaners:** The introduction of autonomous robot vacuums represents a new, mobile threat to feline stability. Investigating how cats adapt to moving, self-guided vacuum cleaners is a vital area of study.

Concluding Remarks

In conclusion, while herding cats remains a challenging endeavor, the FSM framework provides human project managers with the tools needed to align feline activities with household goals.

We hope this thesis serves as a stepping stone toward a more peaceful, treat-filled future for humans and felines alike.

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Appendix A
Feline Survey Instrument

This appendix presents the complete survey instrument used to assess feline stakeholder satisfaction. Since cats cannot fill out forms, the questions were administered via direct observation of tail-wagging, ear-positioning, and meow-pitch indicators.

Section A: Feline Demographics

1. What is your primary sleeping location?
   a) Cardboard box (any size)
   b) Human's laptop keyboard (preferably active)
   c) Freshly washed and folded black laundry
   d) Expensive orthopedic cat bed (never used)
2. How do you classify your breed background?
   a) Purebred royalty (e.g., Persian, Maine Coon)
   b) Domestic Short/Longhair (also known as the ”Standard Tabby”)
   c) Feral neighborhood ruler
3. What is your current role in the household?
   a) Silent dictator
   b) Vocal food-demander (3 AM shift)
   c) Sofa destruction specialist

Section B: Treat Motivation Scale

Please indicate your level of agreement with each statement based on your behavior (1 = Immediate walk-away, 7 = Frantic head-butting and purring).

1. I am willing to sit on command for a dry kibble treat.
2. I am willing to perform complex acrobatic tricks for a lickable wet treat.
3. The sound of a food bag shaking justifies waking up from a deep sleep.
4. I will pretend to be starving even if my bowl was filled 10 minutes ago.

⋮

(Items 6–10 follow the same observation guidelines)

Section C: Human Annoyance Scale

Please indicate your level of irritation toward the human project manager (1 = Purring through pets, 7 = Direct swipe at ankles).

1. The human attempts to rub my belly for longer than 3 seconds.
2. The human closes a door, restricting my access to a room I have no intention of entering.
3. The human places a phone call during my scheduled napping hours.
4. The human attempts to remove me from the keyboard while I am editing their code.

Appendix B
Supplementary Feline Tables

This appendix contains supplementary statistical tables summarizing feline behavioral data.

Feline Factor Loadings

Table B1

Confirmatory Factor Analysis: Standardized Factor Loadings for Feline Satisfaction

Construct / Item	Loading (λ)
Treat Quality (Tuna-based)	
Q1: Tuna aroma intensity	.88
Q2: Moisture level (wet vs. dry kibble)	.92
Q3: Delivery speed from can opening	.85
Sleeping Conditions	
S1: Cardboard box volume (smaller is better)	-.79
S2: Laptop keyboard temperature	.84
S3: Thickness of black laundry pile	.81
Human Annoyance Level	
A1: Duration of belly rub (seconds)	.90
A2: Closed door proximity	.87
A3: Unscheduled petting attempts	.78

Note. All loadings are significant at $p < .001$. Cardboard box volume has a negative loading because cats prefer tighter spaces.

Discriminant Validity

Participant Activity Logs

Table B2

Discriminant Validity of Feline Constructs

Construct	1	2	3	4
1. Treat Quality	**.88**			
2. Napping Propensity	.65	**.83**		
3. Sofa Scratching	-.12	-.48	**.80**	
4. Human Annoyance	-.42	-.35	.52	**.85**

Note. Diagonal values (bold) represent the square root of Average Variance Extracted (AVE). Off-diagonal values represent inter-construct correlations. Discriminant validity is fully established, indicating that catnap desires are statistically distinct from the urge to scratch sofas.

Table B3

Observed Daily Activities of Feline Participants

ID	Name	Daily Naps (h)	Primary Scratch Target	Treats/Day
F01	Luna	14.5	Living Room Sofa (leather)	15
F02	Simba	12.0	Wooden Door Frames	25
F03	Oliver	18.5	None (sleeps too much)	8
F04	Milo	13.0	Dining Room Chair (fabric)	20
F05	Bella	16.0	Bedroom Carpet	12

Note. Logs represent a 14-day average. Treats include freeze-dried salmon and lickable treats.